from Tibet/Ladakh. Such a pact would be somewhat akin to what China and the ASEAN countries are attempting to formalize.[13]

Theatre Commands

Gen Bipin Rawat was appointed as India's first-ever Chief of Defence Staff with effect from 1 January 2020, on completion of a three-year tenure as COAS. As part of the government orders, a Department of Military Affairs was also created, with Gen Rawat also being the Secretary, DMA. In his capacity of CDS, he also became the permanent Chairman of the Chiefs of Staff Committee (COSC), which hitherto had been a rotating appointment, held by the senior-most Service Chief for the balance of his tenure. Gen Rawat (and his successor Gen Anil Chauhan) thus wore three hats, Chairman COSC, CDS and Secy DMA. The mandate of the Department of Military Affairs inter alia included, 'Facilitation of restructuring of Military Commands for optimal utilization of resources by bringing about jointness in operations, including through the establishment of joint/theatre commands'.[14] The emphasis on this aspect in the government notification seemed to suggest that this was the priority. Perhaps as a result of this perception, Gen Rawat outlined a model that was more in the nature of loud thinking, which nevertheless led to a spate of vociferous protestations, especially from the Air Force.

The CDS felt that there could be four to five theatres: two operational theatres for the land borders, two operational theatres for the maritime borders and one functional air defence theatre command. These were to be formed by merging the existing operational Commands of the three Services: six of the Army, two of the Navy and five of the Air Force.[15] The

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